

UPPER YANGTZE FORESTS

Home to China's national treasure, the giant panda

The Upper Yangtze Forests ecoregion comprises three areas: the Qinling Mountains, the Daba Mountains, and the Sichuan Basin. All three form a watershed between the drainage basins of the Yellow River to the north and the Yangtze River to the south. The climate is cooler and more temperate in the north of the region, where the forests are predominantly made up of deciduous trees. To the south are subtropical evergreen forests that flourish in this area's warmer temperatures and plentiful rain.

Rare lowland species

The lowlands of the Sichuan Basin are the most heavily populated. Here most of the land has been turned over to agriculture, but fragments of evergreen and broadleaf forest remain, particularly on the steeper hillsides and on any mountains considered sacred by local people. This area is home to the dawn redwood, an unusual

deciduous conifer that was known only from fossil records until the 1940s, when groups of the trees were discovered growing in Sichuan province.

The Upper Yangtze Forests' most famous inhabitant is the giant panda, and the Wolong Nature Reserve near Chengdu is dedicated to the preservation of this iconic yet rare black-and-white bear. The middle elevations of the Qinling forests in Shaanxi province have a dense bamboo understory, which provides a home and food to a distinctive type of giant panda that has dark- and light-brown fur. The smaller, tree-dwelling red panda also lives in the Upper Yangtze Forests.



YELLOW-THROATED MARTIN

GROUP THREAT
The large, brightly colored yellow-throated marten eats eggs and fruit as well as small prey, such as rodents, reptiles, and ground-nesting birds. Sometimes hunting in small groups, it also kills deer fawns, wild boar piglets, and even giant panda cubs.



CHINESE BAMBOO PARTRIDGE

HIDDEN FORAGER
The common but elusive Chinese bamboo partridge inhabits hillside forests, feeding on seeds, shoots, leaves, and insects. If it cannot remain hidden from predators, it flies uphill, but is much more often heard than seen.

SEX-LINKED STRIPES

The Chinese green tree viper is a venomous snake endemic to Asia. Males and females can be distinguished from one another by a stripe that runs along the side of their bodies. In males, it is orange or brown and white; in females' stripes are just white.

GREEN TREE VIPER

Home to the world's largest amphibian, the Chinese giant salamander

Contains one-fifth

